

group called Lokacharita, led by director G. Channakeshava. Sadly, Channakeshava passed away last year and the project was halted—till last week, when director Umesh Salian helmed an all-new production. The narrative is centred on a wealthy NRI called Vikram, who returns to Bengaluru to visit his childhood home, only to find that the caretaker has duped him and converted it into a 12-storey building.

Vikram's quixotic efforts to reverse the theft of his home form the bulk of the story; along the way he encounters a friend's wife named Madhuri (who reminds him of his eponymous childhood friend), the man who duped him in the first place and another friend named Betala who advises him to drop this well-meaning but ill-advised quest. That last bit alludes to the Vikram-Betaal stories from the *Kathasaritsagara*, an 11th century collection of Sanskrit fables.

"There are three aspects of the Vikram-Betaal story that are of interest to me," says Shanbhag. "The first is the tireless effort of Vikram to fulfil a promise. With every failure, he goes back to start all over again. The second aspect is the condition that Vikram can't keep quiet if he knows the answer. And the third aspect is the complexity of the last question, which cannot be answered using terms you already know; you have to invent something new to answer the last question."

There is a sense of quiet, inevitable despair in Vikram's story, especially when he realises that his mission is probably unrealistic. This sense of inevitability speaks to Bengaluru's 'modernisation' juggernaut and its rapid progression to becoming a 'vertical city'.

"Bangalore resisted this 'vertical movement' up until 25 years ago," Shanbhag says. "The city has lost a large portion of its green cover over the past three decades, without much resistance from its residents. In one of his stories, the Kannada writer Yashwant Chittal describes multi-storey housing as owning only the light and the air of that space, which is itself in mid-air. Moving away from the land has other consequences, too, as Chittal shows us. The view may be completely different from a height, but only the middle-class can afford this view."

Vikram's quixotic efforts to **REVERSE THE THEFT OF HIS HOME** form the bulk of the play

English-language readers in India and elsewhere know Shanbhag as the author of *Ghachar Ghochar*, a 2015 novella (translated into English by Srinath Perur) about the unexpected consequences of one family's rapid upward mobility. *Illiruvudu Summane*, too, features some sharp commentary on the personal and societal costs of untrammelled urbanisation.

"As recently as three decades ago, people who moved to Bangalore connected to the local culture, food, language and so on because they were dependent on these things. But now, the people who live in the city's new hubs, driven by IT employment, see the city only as an infrastructure provider. In suburbs like Whitefield, voter turnout for municipal elections is less than 50 per cent. People are not interested in their immediate surroundings." ■

–Aditya Mani Jha





"The interplay of energies between the actor and the audience makes theatre such a shared experience"

and reshaping and haven't established themselves with long successful runs, like big international hits. But that's what made the journey risky and exciting.

Q. What is it like directing and acting in a play like *Lockdown Liaisons*, which is so rooted in the pandemic, whose horrific memories are still very fresh and alive?

The best thing about *Lockdown Liaisons* is that though it's set in the lockdown, the play is essentially a collection of short stories about human relationships of different kinds. The lockdown is just the trigger that brings things to the surface. Reliving some of what happened was (like the play) partly emotional, partly very moving and partly funny, too. Because it's not just about the lockdown, the play will have a long run, and be relatable for a long time.

Q. You have worked across film, television and theatre. Do you have a favourite medium?

The stage gives an actor the kind of range and freedom to express her talent in a way no other medium can. The stage belongs to an actor, while the screen belongs to a director and his vision. Being producer and director of my own plays, I decide the content of my plays and can talk about any subject that I want to. Plays go where other mediums rarely do.

Q. Many art forms were forced to go digital during the pandemic. Has theatre also had to evolve in an e-avatar?

For me, theatre belongs on stage, in front of a live audience. It's the interplay of energies between the actor and the audience that makes it such an extraordinary shared experience. ■

– with Sukhada Tatke